DEV.CO EXCLUSIVE

Your First Open Source Contribution

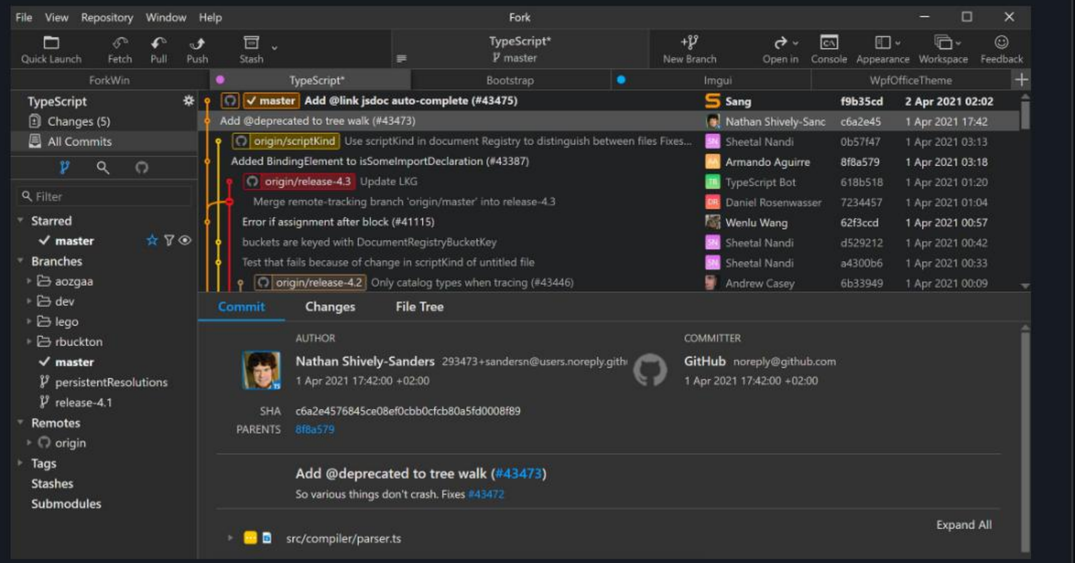
The definitive, step-by-step cheat sheet. From finding a repository on GitHub to executing VS Code terminal commands and merging your first Pull Request.

Step 1: Fork the Repository

Create your own copy

You cannot edit an open-source project directly. You must create a personal copy (a "fork") under your own GitHub account first.

- Navigate to the target project on GitHub.
- Look at the top right corner of the page.
- Click the **Fork** button.



Step 2: Local Setup in VS Code

1. Clone the Fork

Bring the code to your local machine.

```
$ git clone
https://github.com/YOU/repo.git
```

2. Navigate

Move into the new project directory.

```
$ cd repo-name
```

3. Add Upstream

Link to the original project to sync updates.

```
$ git remote add upstream
https:// ...
# Verify with: git remote -v
```

Step 3: Create a Branch

Never make changes directly on the `main` branch. Isolate your work in a descriptive feature branch.

```
# Format: type/short-description
$ git checkout -b fix/login-button-alignment

Switched to a new branch 'fix/login-button-
alignment'
```



Step 4: Make Changes & Commit

Check Status

See which files you have modified in VS Code.

```
$ git status
```

Stage Changes

Add specific files (or all) to the staging area.

```
$ git add .
# or: git add file.js
```

Commit

Save changes with a clear, descriptive message.

```
$ git commit -m "Fix: button alignment"
```

Step 5: Push to Your Fork

Your changes are saved locally, but GitHub doesn't know about them yet. You need to push your newly created branch up to your forked repository on GitHub.

This action makes your code accessible online and sets the stage for the final Pull Request.

```
# Push your local branch to 'origin' (your fork)
$ git push origin fix/login-button-alignment

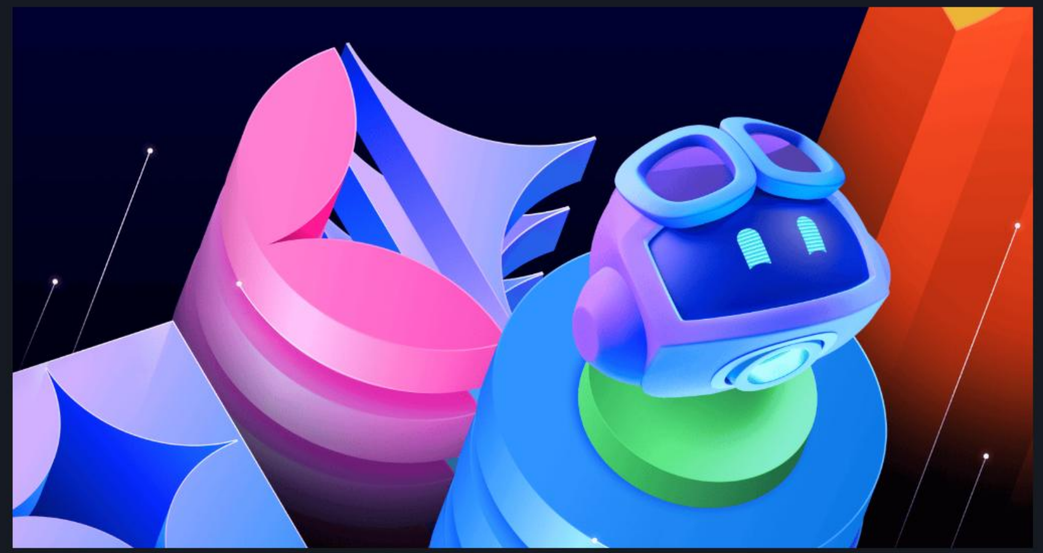
Enumerating objects: 5, done.
Counting objects: 100% (5/5), done.
Writing objects: 100% (3/3), 320 bytes | 320.00 KiB/s, done.
Total 3 (delta 2), reused 0 (delta 0)
To https://github.com/YOU/repo.git
* [new branch] fix/login-button-alignment → fix/login-button-
alignment
```

Step 6: Open a Pull Request

Propose your changes

Go back to the browser and visit the **original** repository on GitHub. GitHub is smart and will notice you just pushed a branch to your fork.

- Click the green **Compare & pull request** button that appears.
- Fill out the PR template. Explain *what* you did and *why*.
- Click **Create pull request** and wait for maintainer review!



Pro Tips for Success

Always Read CONTRIBUTING.md

Most major projects have a guide outlining their specific coding standards, commit message formats, and PR requirements. Read it first!

Keep PRs Small and Focused

Don't try to fix 5 different bugs in one PR. A pull request should do one thing well. Smaller PRs get reviewed and merged much faster.

Be Patient and Receptive

Maintainers are often volunteers. It might take days for a review. If they request changes, don't take it personally—just update your branch and push again!

Ready to Contribute?

You now have the terminal commands and the UI knowledge to make an impact.

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Image Sources



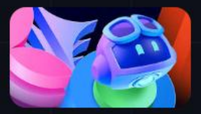
https://git-fork.com/images/image1Win.jpg

Source: git-fork.com



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Source: github.blog